Essential Reading List

9 pieces. That’s it. Each one changes how you think about building.

Phase 1: Before You Start (Read in Week 1-2)

1. Paul Graham — “How to Get Startup Ideas”

Link: https://paulgraham.com/startideas.html **Read time:** 25 min **The insight:** The best startup ideas come from noticing problems you personally have, not from brainstorming. “Live in the future and build what’s missing.” Stop trying to think of startup ideas. Start noticing what’s broken. **Assign before:** Module 2 (Finding Ideas)

2. Paul Graham — “Do Things That Don’t Scale”

Link: https://paulgraham.com/ds.html **Read time:** 15 min **The insight:** Every great startup started with founders doing things manually — recruiting users one by one, delivering the product by hand, writing personal emails. This feels wrong but it’s how you learn. The Airbnb founders photographed apartments themselves. Stripe’s founders installed their software on users’ laptops in person. **Assign before:** Module 8 (Finding First Users)

3. Rob Fitzpatrick — “The Mom Test” (Book)

Link: https://themomtest.com (buy the book — it’s €15 and 130 pages) **Read time:** 2-3 hours **The insight:** People will lie to you about your startup idea because they’re polite. This book teaches you how to ask questions that make it impossible for them to lie. The single most valuable skill for a first-time founder. **Assign before:** Module 3 (The Problem Space)

Phase 2: While Building (Read in Week 3-6)

4. Paul Graham — “Startup = Growth”

Link: https://paulgraham.com/growth.html **Read time:** 20 min **The insight:** A startup is not just a small company. A startup is a company designed for rapid growth. If you’re not growing, you’re a small business — and that’s fine, but it changes every decision you make. Growth rate is the compass. **Assign before:** Module 9 (Prototype to Product)

5. Rahul Vohra / First Round Review — “How Superhuman Built an Engine to Find Product-Market Fit”

Link: https://review.firstround.com/how-superhuman-built-an-engine-to-find-product-market-fit/ **Read time:** 30 min **The insight:** The most concrete, reproducible process ever published for measuring and improving product-market fit. Based on Sean Ellis’s “very disappointed” survey question. Gives you the exact metric (40% threshold), the exact segmentation method, and the exact improvement loop. This is what Dario Amodei would call “intellectual rigor applied to product.” **Assign before:** Module 7 (Rapid Validation)

6. Andrej Karpathy — “Software 2.0”

Link: https://karpathy.medium.com/software-2-0-a64152b37c35 **Read time:** 15 min **The insight:** Traditional software is written by programmers. Software 2.0 is written by optimizers (neural networks) on data. This reframes what it means to “build” an AI product — your moat is in the data and evaluation, not the code. Essential for understanding where AI startup value lives. **Assign before:** Module 6 (Rapid Prototyping with AI)

Phase 3: Scaling & Pitching (Read in Week 7-12)

7. Paul Graham — “How to Raise Money”

Link: https://paulgraham.com/fr.html **Read time:** 20 min **The insight:** Fundraising is a separate skill from building a company. It has its own rules, dynamics, and traps. The most common mistake: raising too early, from the wrong people, for the wrong amount. If you raise, be deliberate about it. **Assign before:** Module 12 (Fundraising)

8. Sam Altman — “Startup Playbook”

Link: https://playbook.samaltman.com **Read time:** 20 min **The insight:** The compressed wisdom of YC in 5,000 words. Covers idea, team, product, execution, and growth in a way that’s specific enough to be actionable. Good capstone reading that ties all modules together. **Assign before:** Module 12 (Final Presentations)

9. YC Startup School — Free Video Course

Link: https://www.startupschool.org **Time commitment:** Pick 3-4 lectures relevant to your current stage **The insight:** 20+ hours of free lectures from YC partners who’ve guided thousands of startups. Not a “watch it all” resource — pick the lecture that matches your current chokepoint. The Michael Seibel lectures on product-market fit and the Dalton Caldwell lectures on evaluating ideas are particularly strong. **Assign as:** Ongoing supplementary resource

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What’s NOT on This List (and Why)

Book/Resource	Why it’s cut
“The Lean Startup” (Eric Ries)	The core ideas (Build-Measure-Learn) are already in the slides. The book is 300 pages of what PG says in 3 pages. Read the Wikipedia summary if curious.
“Sprint” (Jake Knapp)	Designed for design teams at Google with 5-day budgets. Student teams can’t afford this level of structure.
“Zero to One” (Peter Thiel)	Philosophically interesting but not actionable for a 12-week course.
“Business Model Canvas” (Osterwalder)	The canvas is more useful for optimizing existing businesses than for discovering new ones. Use Lean Canvas if you need a visual.
Any growth hacking book	Premature optimization. Get 10 paying users first.
“Crossing the Chasm” (Geoffrey Moore)	Relevant at Series B, not at pre-seed.

Bonus: The Best Free Resources from Top Accelerators & VCs

These aren't required reading — they're the "go deeper" layer for students who want it. Each one is publicly available and battle-tested by thousands of founders.

Validation & Product-Market Fit

Resource	Source	Link	Why it matters
Arc PMF Framework	Sequoia Capital	sequoiacap.com/article/pmf-framework/	Sequoia's internal framework, now public. Three archetypes of PMF (Hair-on-Fire, Hard-Fact, Future-Vision). The best PMF mental model that exists.
Arc Terrifying Questions	Sequoia Capital	sequoiacap.com/article/pmf-framework-2/	Four questions your startup must answer before scaling. Forces brutal honesty.
PMF Survey Tool	Sean Ellis / GoPractice	pmfsurvey.com	Free tool to run the "How would you feel?" survey. Ready-made, no setup needed.
Lean LaunchPad Lectures	Steve Blank	steveblank.com/slides	All slides and videos free under Creative Commons. The original customer development methodology.

Fundraising & Pitch

Resource	Source	Link	Why it matters
How to Build a Seed Pitch Deck	Y Combinator	ycombinator.com/library/2u	YC's official guide. Traction-first structure.
SAFE Agreement	Y Combinator	ycombinator.com/documents	The industry-standard early-stage investment doc. Free, open-source.
Sequoia Pitch Deck Template	Sequoia Capital	slideshare: Sequoia Pitch Deck	The original 10-slide structure every VC expects.
Real Pitch Deck Examples	Slidebean	slidebean.com/pitch-deck-examples	35+ real pitch decks from Airbnb, Buffer, Uber, etc. — see what actually got funded.

Accelerator Curricula (Free)

Resource	Source	Link	Why it matters
Startup School	Y Combinator	startupschool.org/curriculum	7-week free curriculum. Lectures on ideas, PMF, growth, fundraising by YC partners. The gold standard.
YC Startup Library	Y Combinator	ycombinator.com/library	Searchable archive of all YC essays, videos, and guides.
Entrepreneur's Toolkit	TechStars	toolkit.techstars.com	Free modules on Lean Canvas, pitch, PMF (W3 framework), and founder mental health. Practical, concise.
Antler Launch Academy	Antler	antler.co	Free 5-week course: idea generation, design thinking, MVP, team, fundraising.
Startup Templates	EWOR	ewor.com/startup-templates	Free templates: Co-Founder Agreement, OKRs, Investor Updates, Financial Models, Pitch Deck, Data Room. Excellent for later-stage course modules.

Founder Thinking & Mental Models

Resource	Source	Link	Why it matters
a16z Company Building	Andreessen Horowitz	a16z.com/category/company-building/	Deep essays on hiring, culture, fundraising, and scaling from a16z partners.
a16z AI Canon	Andreessen Horowitz	a16z.com/ai-canon/	Curated list of the most important AI papers, courses, and guides. Essential for AI-first founders.
First Round Review	First Round Capital	review.firstround.com	The best long-form founder interviews on the internet. Their “Must Reads” and “Starting Up” collections are exceptional.
Best of First Round 2024	First Round Capital	30 Best Pieces of Advice 2024	Annual compilation of the year’s best founder advice.
Founder Tools & Blogs	Steve Blank	steveblank.com/tools	Curated list of tools for every startup stage from the godfather of customer development.
EF Edge Framework	Entrepreneur First	joinef.com	Ideation through “edges” — your unfair advantage as a founder. Useful for Module 2 students stuck on ideas.
Indie Hackers	Community	indiehackers.com	Real founders sharing real revenue numbers. Good for staying grounded on what “traction” actually looks like.

How to Read

Don’t read linearly. Read the piece assigned for your current module, then come back to it after running your experiments. The second reading always reveals something the first didn’t, because now you have context from your own failures.

Budget: 2-3 hours of reading per week. No more. The rest of your time should be spent talking to customers and building.